

KF35 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Lectio Divina

Assume your meditation posture and breathe. Straighten your neck as you lower your chin a little. Allow your shoulders to relax and fall back. *(Pause)* You might use the word *CALM* to center yourself. Take the next minute to scan your body for tension and then release it on the exhale. Breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

1. Read the passage

I will read a short sentence from the Bible and then pause. Our text is John 17:17 in which Jesus prays for His people.

*Set them apart into the truth.
(Repeat) (Pause for 10 seconds)*

2. Receive as you listen

Relax while I read this sentence three times, pausing between readings. On the last reading I will use the first-person pronoun. Take the attitude of a listener and gently observe your experience with the words. Let's begin. *(Use the singular pronoun for the last reading)*

*Set them (me) apart into the truth.
(Read 3 times, pausing for 30 seconds after each reading)*

3. Respond

Respond to God with affirmation and gratitude. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. Rest in awareness

Rest in stillness for one minute as you contemplate what you have experienced during this time. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and re-engage with your environment. You may wish to take this next minute to record your

experience in your KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you might wish to simply wait.
(*Pause for 1 minute*)

Pause. You can practice the **Lectio Divina** by reading the entire chapter of John 17 and then focusing on a phrase or verse that strikes you, or you might meditate on any other passage or story from the Bible. Take a little time to explore the Scripture through repetition and listening. Breathe, and let God reorient your spirit with the truth of the words.

Our hymn for KF Confession 8 is *And Can It Be?*

Long my imprisoned spirit lay,
Fast-bound in sin and nature's night.
Thine eye diffused a quickening ray—
I woke, the dungeon flamed with light!
My chains fell off, my heart was free;
I rose, went forth, and followed Thee.
My chains fell off, my heart was free;
I rose, went forth, and followed Thee.¹

Take a deep breath.

(*If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?"*)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 8 reminds us of our real business:

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

This month I have been talking about our CORE strength—courage, orientation, reality, and endurance. Strong CORE muscles are necessary for tackling the challenges that lie ahead as we seek and save what has been lost. We have already looked at courage and orientation. Courage is feeling the fear and yet choosing orientation anyway. Orientation is a state of flow and harmony with God and the Creation, and we enter into this dynamic state through something called obedience. In KF we use the word *orientation* to help us expand our understanding of *righteousness*, a word often used in English translations of the Bible. As we seek and train our True Self, our orientation to God is perfected and our lives become a clearer and truer representation of who God is and who He designed us to be.

Guidance from the Bible is often a system of limitations that empowers, defines, and orients our True Self. This guidance strikes at the heart of the Idol. Sometimes when we do what the Bible tells us to do, we feel like we are losing our lives. The Idol Self does not want to acknowledge any limitations, so if you find yourself resisting God's guidance, know that it is your Idol Self at work. Just observe that feeling of resistance, which is neither good or evil. You might use a worksheet to explore the pride or fear that is behind your resistance. Obedience demonstrates our choice to live in the reality of our design. To obey is simply to agree with God as to what is good for us. As God's creatures, we are designed to enjoy a fulfilling relationship with our Creator, and we can only flourish when that relationship is our goal. Let's explore this idea of reality.

1. What is reality?

Reality is what you have to deal with today. It includes your personal strengths, weaknesses, and antecedents—and those of others. It also includes the prescribed limitations and enforced order of civil law and your community culture. Another reality that cannot be avoided is the universal law of cause and effect.

If we are to dwell in love, our commitment to reality is essential. If we prefer illusions, we cannot love no matter what our imagination tells us. Love rejoices in the truth, so we are learning to embrace realities with joy and to creatively manage those realities using our KF tools. We are not living in reality if our actions do not support our desired outcomes and we just keep talking about those outcomes without becoming the cause. When we are rejoicing in illusions, we are not rejoicing in the truth; and when we are not rejoicing in the truth, we cannot love ourselves, our community, or God.² If we live in illusions and believe what is not real, we are unable to accept the vicissitudes of reality and cannot recognize the opportunities that reality presents. Our souls become overburdened with toxic anxiety and wrath, which weakens our endurance. Our lives then stagnate, and we stop circulating. We cannot endure because we are working against realities. It's like carrying two hundred pounds of weight while trying to run a mile. Your work in Karis Fellowships helps you unload that extra weight and get back into circulation.

2. Who are you, really?

God created you to be an eternally unfolding discovery to yourself, to others, and to Him. When you are busy judging yourself, hating yourself, or controlling and suppressing yourself, it's difficult to explore yourself. You will make up all sorts of stories about why you should not use time and resources for exploration and self-discovery. These stories seem credible because in the past you have successfully used them to alleviate anxiety and psychically survive. They feel logical because they help you maintain your pride system and justify your search for glory. Stories and excuses tend to be driven by fear—fear of yourself, fear of what others will think or do, and fear of what you might lose.

Stories and fears are part of a family's ecosystem. Families use stories to explain their anxiety and to maintain a sense of unity and solidarity. Members of anxious families are not encouraged to build healthy self-confidence and fear-free lives because their independence would threaten family unity. We carry family fears within us and use them to avoid our healthy development. With courage, we can confront these fears and choose the path that will lead us home to our True Self.

3. It is real that you are a human creature

Every human being is a creature, and since you are human, you are also a creature. Like every other creature, you are finite and impermanent in this material world and subject to the limitations of an animal. You must sleep, eat, and evacuate. You procreate. Your body dies. You only have twenty-four hours in a day. You must appropriate time and resources to care for your body, your soul, and your mental health. You must play, and you must work. You must be active, and you must rest. You must make mistakes, and just like any puppy or lion cub, you must be trained to reach your potential. You are not a god. You are a creature with limitations. This is a reality.

4. You are subject to the limitations of the Creation

There are physical laws, and there are energetic laws. There are civil, social, and financial laws—and there are spiritual laws for healing and growth. These laws apply to everyone, and they function on the principle of cause and effect. So, if you want to achieve a particular outcome, you will have to live within the limitations of cause and effect, or action and result. Physical health is the result of healthy

life-style choices. Income is the result of productive work. Trusting relationships are the result of trustworthy choices. If you want a relationship with God, you must practice trusting Him. If you want to live in a safe and productive society, you must honor the limitations of civil law. Whenever you rebel against the law of cause and effect or simply ignore it, you create unnecessary stresses for yourself and for others. I think that most functioning people understand these things.

Your soul needs healing. A stable life with few external stresses provides the time and resources that you need to heal your soul. Of course, the Idol will undermine your efforts to create that stability because stability supports the development of the True Self. Your Idol needs you to be constantly craving and discontent so that it can drive your search for glory and compel you to choose cheap, habitual short-cuts to relieve anxiety. The Idol will encourage you to fight or ignore real limitations in order to keep you unstable. Unfortunately, most of us are addicted to stress and drama. Stress, drama, and conflict make us feel alive and engaged. If we stop generating stress and drama, we feel lost and anxious and suffer just like any other addict giving up an addiction. Peace is frightening for most of us, and we must be trained to make peace and maintain it; otherwise we will slide back into our comfort zone of stress and discontent. When you live in peace, which is only possible if the True Self is in charge, you strengthen your ability to respond to reality. A peaceful life has fewer distractions, allowing you to focus on your business and to free up resources for personal growth. You can calm down and grow.

5. How do you invest in your True Self?

If you want to invest in your True Self, you must learn to live within the limitations of God's design and His rules for physical, mental, and spiritual health. KF training teaches you how to do that. The practice of mindfulness helps you observe and explore your present reality; you learn to recognize your shoulds, your claims, and your pride system, as well as your preferences and delights. You also have your KF toolbox. You can reach in and choose a tool to help you unload the extra baggage of idolatry that cripples your courage and your ability to endure.

Unloading extra baggage is like digging up our own field in order to uncover what lies beneath. The True Self is the treasure that we find.³ This treasure has always been there, but uncovering it requires our effort. In KF we work with hope, trusting that we can and will discover our precious True Self. We are worth working for.

In First Corinthians, chapter 13, Paul uses the metaphor of a mirror to help us understand the process of growing into our True Self. When we are not living according to the logos of love, our understanding of life is like that of a child who has no real knowledge or experience and makes up stories based on illusions. In this immature condition, we see only a bewildering puzzle when we look into the mirror of our lives. Our souls are disconnected and compartmentalized, so we find ourselves believing one thing and doing another, valuing the material over the spiritual, chronically choosing cheap habitual short-cuts to manage our problems and feel good about ourselves, and ignoring the interaction of cause and effect between the seen and unseen. But when we learn to live in trust, hope, and love, we grow up. We uncover and develop the True Self. We give up the fantasies and delusions that maintain our pride and justify our greedy pleasures. We then see our developing True Self in the mirror of our lives; we come to know ourselves as God knows us. The truth about our lives, about ourselves, and about God becomes a congruent foundation for our choices and sacrifices, as well as for our mission and potential.

In First Corinthians 13:12, Paul writes:

Let me explain. Now we see through a mirror of riddles, but then face to face. Now I know pieces of myself, but then I shall know my whole self, even as I am known by God.⁴

There are a number of non-KF tools that have also helped KF members glimpse the pearl of their True Self.⁵ One of these tools is the *Myers-Briggs Type Indicator* assessment, which helps you identify the characteristics associated with your personality type. There are several books available that offer and explain the assessment, and you can go online to find descriptions of the different types.⁶ These descriptions may help you recognize aspects of your True Self. If you have taken the indicator test in the past, you might take it again now that you have been dismantling the Idol. If there is someone in your life who knows you well and loves you enough to be honest, you might ask them to take the test for you. They will have the perspective of knowing you by your fruit and will not be biased by your search for glory. There are a number of books available that introduce the Myers-Briggs assessment. I particularly like *Please Understand Me* by David Keirsey and Marilyn Bates because their approach is quite compassionate.

Another tool that some KF members have found helpful often triggers fear and judgment in Christians. This particular tool is a combination of science and art and is as old as the human experience with God. Perhaps you can just observe this suggestion without taking the Judgment Path. Suggestions are not good or bad! My aim is to give you whatever help I can. I am simply offering a tool that has helped many Christians get a clearer picture of their True Self.

We know that God created cycles and seasons in the material world and, also, in our lives. In Genesis 1:14–20, we learn that God designed these cycles and seasons to be governed, or directed, by the sun, the moon, and the stars. These lights were created to be signs and indicators. Later in Scripture, we see God using these lights to teach people and even to lead them to Jesus.⁷ We also learn from Psalm 19 that the heavens declare the glory of God.

Some Christians believe that it benefits us and God's purposes if we understand and flow with what the lights in the heavens reveal about our unique design and its potential. Our goal in KF is to harmonize and flow with the Creation, so this tool is worth considering. The tendencies, talents, and preferences inherent in our design incline us toward particular pathways that lead either to the freedom of our true glory or to the prison of illusions and pride. It is then our responsibility to choose the paths that allow us to fulfill our potential and declare the glory of God through our lives. The word *astrology* means *knowledge that comes from stars*. This knowledge has nothing to do with reading astrology columns in newspapers or analyzing the position of planets and stars to make daily choices. Christians who use this tool are not practicing the ancient worship of the hosts of heaven, nor are they replacing their trust in God with trust in the stars.

Throughout history, very capable and influential Christians have studied astrology—John Milton, Sir Isaac Newton, and Carl Jung, to name just a few. Also, many Christian works, writings, and architecture from the Middle Ages reveal the influence of astrology on western thought. In the Renaissance, astrology was a scholarly tradition, and its symbolism was widely understood. Even if you don't believe in the philosophy behind astrology, understanding its symbols can enrich your appreciation of European literature, art, and culture.⁸

Properly understood, classical astrology can be a means of knowing something about your original design—the unique and glorious God-given design that has been yours from the moment you first drew breath, before you were kidnapped by the world, the flesh, and the devil. The cycles that you were born under bypass any illusions that you have built up about yourself because those cycles existed before you created those illusions. The early influence of your personal life constellation is just another aspect of

reality and has its own limitations and freedoms. Many people report that a capable astrologer has helped them identify their strengths and weaknesses more quickly and efficiently than professional aptitude testing—and less expensively. One blog post that you may find interesting is *Astrology from a Christian Perspective*.⁹

Finally, feedback from others can give you a glimpse of your True Self. It is a tremendous help to me when my family members and friends who are working on their own orientation remind me of who I really am. They are able to see my consistent and natural choices, my strengths and weaknesses, and my limitations—and they can remember my spontaneous feelings better than I can. They help guide me when I cannot guide myself. We are trustworthy when our pride system is under firm management. If we can be trusted to respond with gratitude and moderation, others can safely reflect back to us areas of our lives that need orienting. Their observations are so valuable. Members of a trustworthy community can also help us recognize the natural strengths and unique abilities that we could employ for our mission. They can encourage us to have mercy on our True Self when it shines in all of its underdevelopment and lack of skill. Their example and their support teach us to be understanding and compassionate toward ourselves, and as we learn to do that, we are able to extend understanding and compassion toward others in our karis community.

This week, you might pray this prayer:

Designer of my soul, I want to know my True Self. Show me how to bring it to the light. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

Let’s turn to **Philippians 4:4–9** and read these verses in my translation.

⁴Take your pleasure in the Lord at all times. I will say it again, take pleasure in Him. ⁵Let your oriented and capable abilities be known to everyone. Let others know that through you the Lord is near. ⁶Treat nothing with anxious care, but in everything by prayer and entreaty, mixed with thankfulness, let God know what you want, ⁷and the peace of God in Christ Jesus, which exceeds and has a wider extension than all of your limited reasoning, will keep watch over your motivations and perceptions. ⁸And beyond that, siblings, in all your dealings take into account what is true, what is divinely noble, what is oriented and just, what is undefiled and pure, what is beloved, what imparts good omen. Notice if anything is excellent and commendable. ⁹And make it your business to practice the things that you have learned and taken to yourself, as well as what you have heard and seen in me, and the God of peace will be with you.

Take a deep breath.

Who wants reality? Sometimes reality feels like a grim existence, full of hard slogging, frustrations, and

anxiety. Reality seems to be only bills and calories, taxes and death, government goof-ups, social issues, and relationship problems—but that is not true. These perceptions come from the Idol Self. Like an expert in war propaganda, the Idol uses false reasonings to convince us that reality is our enemy and illusion is our friend. The True Self thrives in reality, so if the Idol can convince us to hate and resist reality, we are only one small step away from hating and resisting the True Self.

God, however, only works in reality. He works with the truth of who we are and the truth about our development. He wants reality to become our natural habitat. If we choose to live in reality rather than illusion, and courageously grapple with the challenges, limitations, and possibilities of real life, God can confidently trust us with all the marvelous experiences, fun, and delights that He has in mind. Our job is to consistently maintain our focus on reality and, in each moment, to make choices that manage reality with orientation. We can learn to live in the light of what really is.

Here are a few points that I would like you to consider from this passage.

1. Take your pleasures with the Lord in mind

The Idol Self uses pleasure to escape reality and to escape the real God. The True Self experiences pleasure while enjoying God, His creation, and His gifts. These real pleasures reveal aspects and characteristics of your True Self, and your capacity to enjoy them increases as you continue to pursue orientation. So, as your True Self grows, you will experience more and more pleasure.

The quality of our work toward orientation is revealed by how we use pleasure. God is longing to share with us His delights, but if we use our capacity for pleasure to medicate, escape, or stagnate, He cannot trust us with these gifts. Oriented pleasures often look very different from the illusions of pleasure imposed on us by propaganda. Our culture and the market economy teach us that we are entitled to pleasure, and they encourage us to exploit the chemistry of pleasure to overload our sensors and find oblivion. Our Idol Self uses pleasure to escape reality and to escape the presence of the real God. Pleasure for the Idol is a means of maintaining our pride system, flouting limitations, and generating self-hate. In KF, however, we are learning to experience pleasure as a gift that supports stable, capable, and productive living. When we are able to experience pleasure without feeding the Idol, we prove to God that we can be trusted with real pleasures and can enjoy gratefully, and without snatching, all that He is longing to share with us.

2. Prayer is real

God listens to oriented people who are guarding the commandments of Jesus in their lives. When we are working on our orientation, we can tell God what we want. Pray and ask. He actually pays attention to us! If you will take your real glory seriously, God is free to take your desires seriously. He wants to take your wants into account as He trains you for your mission. Your glory is the expression of who you were created to be. Your mission is the arena in which the world gets to see your glory and witness through you the glory of God.

3. God's peace is real, more real than our stories or logic

Real peace is not found in the stories and logic that we use to relieve our anxiety and restore our pride. Unshakable peace is the fruit of trusting in God's desire and ability to be active in our lives as we choose to live in reality and cooperate with Him. We are not alone in our efforts to grow. All living things depend on external factors for their development, and we are no exception. God is a real player in our lives, and He provides skilled people in the community who can help us learn to live in reality. Look around you and see who they might be. Skilled teachers and mentors can show you the way.

As you learn to train hard, the strained and compulsive life of the Idol will eventually give way to the peace of God. If you lose God's peace, you are either being challenged to grow, or you have lost your way. When you are invited to take up a challenge, it is natural to feel anxiety for a time while you let go of old addictive patterns. If, however, you find that your peace has been swallowed up in misorientation, admit that you have lost your way and take action. When I lose my peace, I know it is time to pray, get help, and train.

Try not to become anxious if you lose your peace. What you thought was peace may have been your survival pattern of shutting-down and ignoring evidence, and this illusion of peace could simply be a way of withdrawing from responsibility. Losing this kind of peace is actually beneficial. It is an invitation to engage with reality and take the next courageous step toward your glory.

4. Our choices are real

Through Jesus, God has shown us what human glory looks like. However, we are not conformed to this glorious image by magic or without effort on our part. We have to make choices that lead us toward that goal. There are things we must choose to take on, and there are things we must choose to give up.

5. Our spiritual nature is real

Reality also includes the marvelous things that stream from the unseen—those flashes of understanding that are like beacons guiding us home. Mindfulness training helps us catch these moments of inspiration that remind us of who we are and where we are really going. With training, we can stay focused on realities that are divinely noble, oriented and just, undefiled and pure, excellent and commendable, beloved, and imparting good omen. These realities help us stick to our business and encourage us as we explore our possibilities. Maintaining this focus trains our material existence to cooperate with and express the reality of our spiritual nature.

What does it mean to *impart good omen*? Good omen can be understood as a future possibility for good, and to impart good omen is to be mindfully aware that every event leads to our higher purpose as God's people. We can embrace all possibilities without inviting the sabotages of self-hate, and we can learn to foster a healthier tomorrow by making oriented choices today.

By consistently focusing on reality, we become mature in our ability to handle life. In other words, we are able to maintain our balance in the material world of cause and effect and do the work that God has given us to do.

This is my translation of First Peter 2:9. In this verse, the apostle describes the real mission of our redeemed True Self and our true identity as the children of God.

You are a select generation, a sovereign priesthood, a company set apart, a people kept safe so that you may proclaim the wonders and goodness of Him who invited you to come out of the darkness and enter into His marvelous light.

Take a deep breath.

Let's continue training so that we might become the glorious people God designed us to be.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God and Savior, I want to proclaim Your wonders and Your goodness through my life. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a situation in which you might choose reality. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider a situation in which you might choose reality*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push away the positive evidence, perhaps the evidence of how well you are actually doing or how positive a situation really is. Perhaps you push away positive evidence because a situation doesn't meet your standards. You might find yourself pushing away what you do not wish to recognize or are afraid to acknowledge. Breathe.
(Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice how it signals you when you *consider this situation in which you might choose reality*. Gently focus your attention on those signals. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider choosing reality*. Is your experience right now pleasant, unpleasant, or vague and slippery? Just observe. *(Pause)* Are you afraid of seeing the real, positive evidence of change in yourself or in others? Are you resisting what the truth is teaching you? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore what is real.

- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth and His desire to liberate you through the truth.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you and others have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹⁰

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I learn to mindfully rejoice in reality, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As I learn to mindfully rejoice in reality, I let go of the craving for admiration and affection.
- As I learn to mindfully rejoice in reality, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.
- As I learn to mindfully rejoice in reality, I let go of the craving for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for our healing and training. Hold us in the power of the truth of who we actually are and what we have been created to do. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*Registration is open for next year’s NHG book study. All KF members are welcome to attend and are also invited to sign up on the website to facilitate one or more of the sessions.

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)*

¹ *And Can It Be?* by Charles Wesley (1707–1788); www.youtube.com/watch?v=sQeIGbKgiw8.

² 1 Cor. 13:6.

³ Matt. 13:44.

⁴ 1 Cor. 13:12 in Nancy’s translation.

⁵ Matt. 13:45–46.

⁶ www.humanmetrics.com/cgi-win/jtypes2.asp.

⁷ Job 9:9, 38:30-32; Matt. 2:1–11.

⁸ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_astrology.

⁹ www.thoughtco.com/astrology-from-a-christians-perspective-207246.

¹⁰ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.